HANDS-ON BRIEF

The AI Building-Block Sketch

One page. Six boxes. A mark on every relationship.

What you are producing

An entity diagram of a capability, not a high-level design. Six boxes, three lines inside each one, and a mark on every relationship saying whether it is one or many. You will draw it on excalidraw.com, export it as a PNG and paste it in the chat. The page is the work product, not the conversation that produced it.

The marks are the point. One of something and many of something are different systems, and the place where that changes is almost always where the first attempt failed.

Step 1: write the sentence before you draw anything

Somebody has already decided to use AI. Your job is not to argue with the sentence. Your job is to draw what has to exist for it to survive a real working day. Write it down first, in this exact shape:

"Let us use AI to _____, so that _____."

- One line. The voice of a person in a meeting, not an architect.
- No technology in it. No vendor in it. No mention of a model.
- The second half has to name somebody whose work is being removed. That person is box 5.

The worked example used in the room is:

"Let us use AI to take drive-thru orders, so the crew can stop wearing headsets."

Step 2: draw six boxes, with three lines in each

Every box carries a name, an owner and one number. Nothing else. If a box has no owner, write NOBODY and leave it there, because that is a finding and not a gap to be tidied up.

BOX	WHAT IT HOLDS
1 . THE ASK	The sentence a real person says, in their words, in the noise they say it in.
2 . THE GROUNDING	What it is allowed to look at today, and who keeps that list correct.
3 . THE MODEL CALL	The part everyone argues about first. Usually it is not one call, it is three.
4 . THE CHECK	What stops a wrong answer reaching anybody, and who graded it.
5 . THE HANDOFF	Who picks it up when it fails, and how many of them there are.
6 . THE RECORD	What gets written down so that tomorrow you can tell whether it worked.

Step 3: mark every relationship

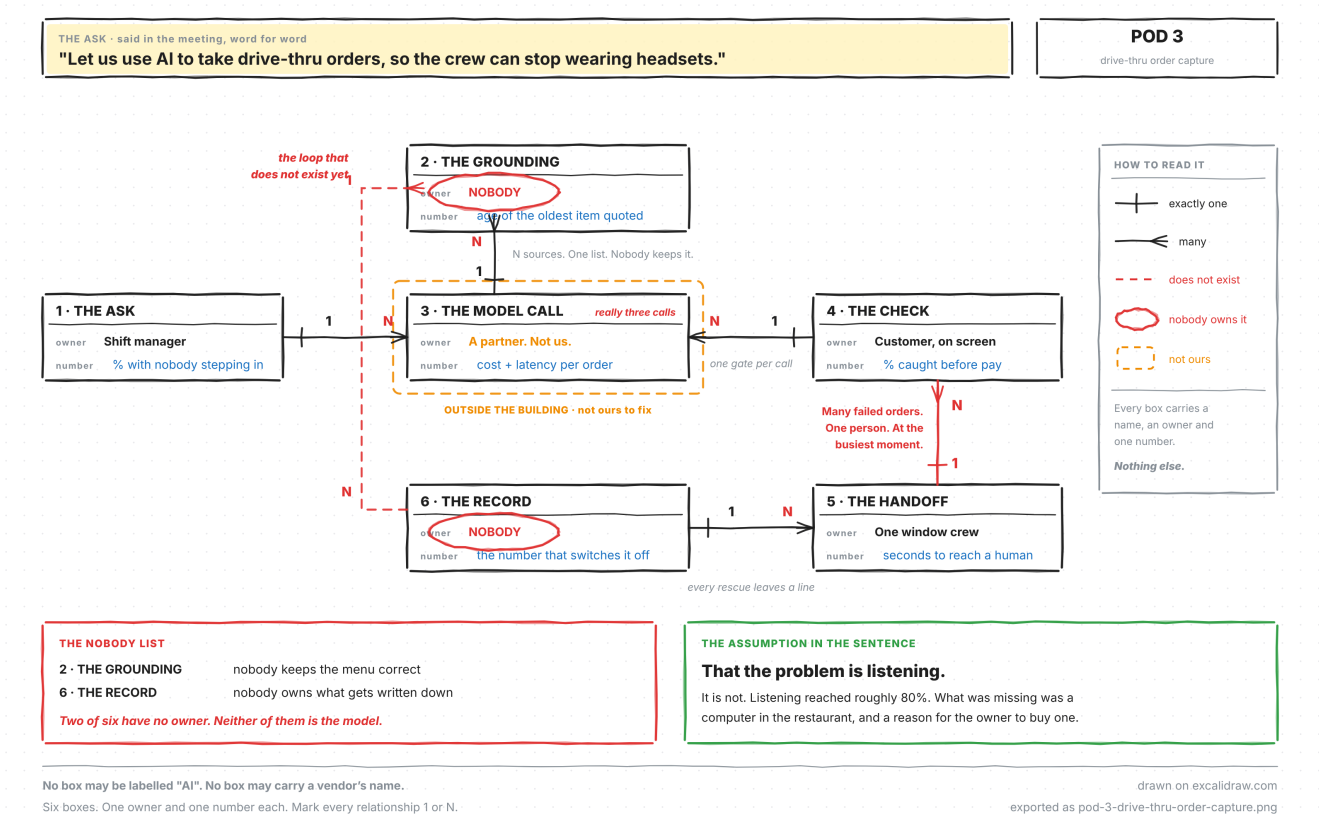
Draw the line between two boxes, then mark each end. Five marks, and that is the whole notation:

MARK	MEANS
A single cross tick	Exactly one of these.
A crow's foot (three lines)	Many of these.
A red dashed line	This relationship should exist and does not exist yet.
A red ring round an owner	Nobody owns this box.
An orange dashed outline	This box is not ours to fix. Somebody else owns it.

Both excalidraw.com and draw.io can do all five. In Excalidraw, use the arrow tool and type the 1 or the N as a small text label next to each end; draw the crow's foot as three short lines. In draw.io, the ER shape library has 1 and N endings built in, under More Shapes, Entity Relation. Either is fine. Excalidraw is faster and has Live collaboration, so one person in the pod can open a canvas and share the link with the rest.

The worked example, finished

This is the drive-thru sentence drawn out in full. Yours will look like this, with your own capability in it.



The three marks worth copying from it:

- THE CHECK, many, to THE HANDOFF, one. Many failed orders, one person, at the busiest moment. That single crow's foot is why a system that is right four times out of five can still make the shift worse than no system at all.
- THE MODEL CALL, one, to THE GROUNDING, many. One list, many sources, and nobody keeping it. The many is why staleness is structural rather than bad luck.

- THE RECORD back to THE GROUNDING, drawn as a red dashed line. Nothing flows back, so the system cannot learn from what it got wrong. A missing relationship is a legitimate mark.

Step 4: the two findings at the bottom of the page

- THE NOBODY LIST. Every box with no owner, copied out underneath. Then one sentence saying how many of the six have no owner, and whether any of them is the model.
- THE ASSUMPTION IN THE SENTENCE. One line naming what the ask takes for granted. On the drive-thru sentence it is that the problem is listening, which it was not.

These two boxes are the payload. Neither of them can be copied off the slide, and they are what gets read out.

The Resultant to hand it back on main screen:

Format:

"We are using AI to [outcome]. The model is not the risk. The risk is [the box nobody owns] and [the junction that breaks under load], and we should switch it off if [the kill number]."

Worked Example (intentionally kept in white, else will be too obvious & would defeat the entire purpose :)):

Step 5: make it argue back

When the page is drawn, paste a photograph of it into whatever assistant you have open, with this:

"Here is my six-block sketch. Act as the architect who has to operate this in production. Tell me four things and nothing else: which box is really three boxes, which relationship I have marked 1 that is actually N, which of my six numbers nobody will ever look at, and the box I have left out entirely. Do not redesign it and do not name a vendor."

Do not accept the first answer. If it suggests a vendor or redesigns your sketch, say so and make it answer the four questions. Mark the four answers onto the same page in a second colour, including the ones you intend to reject. The second colour is the part that shows you learned something.

The one rule

No box may be labelled "AI" and no box may carry a vendor name. If you cannot say what a box does without naming a product, you have drawn a purchase order rather than an architecture.

What good looks like

- Six boxes, not four.
- At least one NOBODY still on the page at the end.
- A number under THE RECORD that would genuinely make you switch the thing off.
- Every relationship marked, including the one you had to argue about before you marked it.

Handing it in

Export the PNG from excalidraw.com and paste it in the chat. Name it with your pod number and the capability, for example pod-3-drive-thru-order-capture.png. Nothing here is collected or marked. The page is yours to take back to work.

Your sentence

Let us use AI to ____, so that ____.